

SYLPH

A FREE GUIDE

FOR ARCHITECTS AND INTERIOR DESIGNERS

The Press-Worthy Project

7 things editors look for before they feature a home. And how to get yours ready, even if you have never been published before.

FROM THE EDITORS OF SYLPH · WITH A NOTE FROM PRERNA PANDEY, FOUNDER

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Gingham Dreams by MuseLAB, a Sylph Spotlight. A 3,000 sq ft Mumbai home built around one idea.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Architects and interior designers with a project they are proud of, finished or close to it, who want it seen by the families who commission homes like it.



Prerna Pandey, Founder of Sylph, with the ANCA edition at Wat Chalong Temple, Thailand.

A NOTE FROM THE FOUNDER

Most great projects never reach print. Not because they are not good enough.

Every edition, I see beautiful work that does not make it in.

It arrives as a folder of photographs with no story. Or it is half finished. Or it was shot for a phone screen, not for a printed page.

This guide is what I wish every architect and designer knew before writing to a magazine. It is short and practical, and it is what our editors look for when they choose what goes into the homes of India's most discerning families.

Read it once now. Then read it again before your next shoot.

Prerna Pandey

FOUNDER, SYLPH

INTRODUCTION

Why good projects stay unpublished

Picture your best project on the coffee table of the family who will commission your next one. They turn the page, stop, and say: "Who did this?"

That is what a feature does. It puts your work, in an editor's voice, in front of people who would never click an ad.

But most studios never get there. They send a folder of photographs and hear nothing back. They wait for the perfect project. Or they pay an agent far more than the page is worth.

The good news: getting featured is not about luck or knowing someone. It is about giving an editor what they need to tell your story.

In this guide you will discover:

- ✓ The 7 things editors look for before they feature a home
- ✓ The shot list that gives an editor everything they need
- ✓ The 5 mistakes that quietly keep good projects out
- ✓ How to write your project in 150 words
- ✓ A one-page checklist to run before you send anything



A residence by M.A.D Collaborative, from its Sylph feature.

48	EDITIONS A YEAR, FOUR A MONTH
60,000+	COPIES A YEAR, HAND-DELIVERED TO UHNI AND HNI HOMES
4	COVERS A MONTH, ONE PER EDITION
7,000+	BRANDS AND STUDIOS SINCE 2021



PART ONE

7 things editors look for

Most designers think great photography is enough. It helps. But editors are choosing stories, and a story needs more than pictures.

1

A story, not a slideshow

An editor is not asking "Is this beautiful?" They are asking "What is this about?"

Every home has a story. A family that needed three generations under one roof. A plot with one great tree. A client who collects art and needed walls that could change. Start there.

If you cannot say what your project is about in one sentence, the editor cannot either.

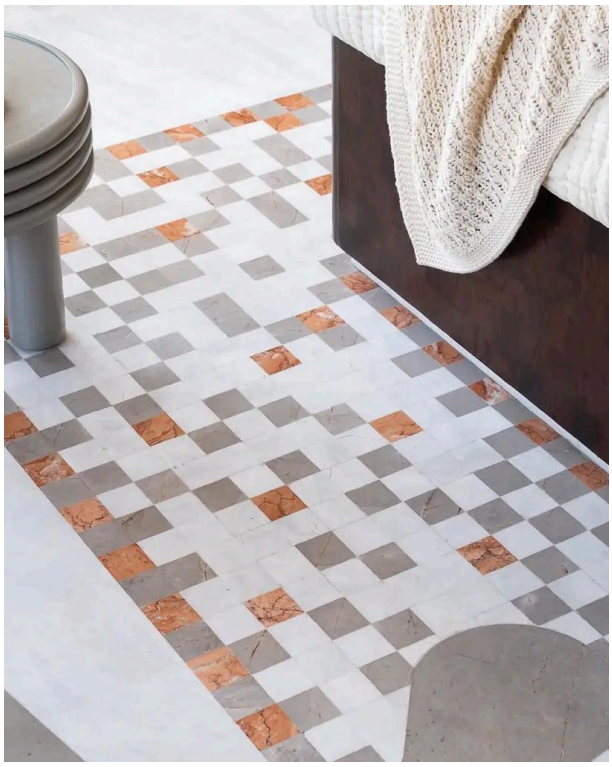
> "Every residence begins with its own circumstances: its context, its architecture and the aspirations of the people who will inhabit it."
>
> FROM M.A.D COLLABORATIVE'S SYLPH FEATURE

2

One clear idea

The projects that get featured usually have one big idea that runs through every room. Not ten ideas. One.

It could be a pattern, a material, a view, or a way of living. Once the idea is clear, every photograph and every line of the story can point back to it.



FROM THE PAGES

MuseLAB's Gingham Dreams, a 3,000 sq ft Mumbai home for a multi-generational family, takes one familiar idea, gingham, and carries it through the whole apartment in marble inlays, geometric grids and handcrafted details.

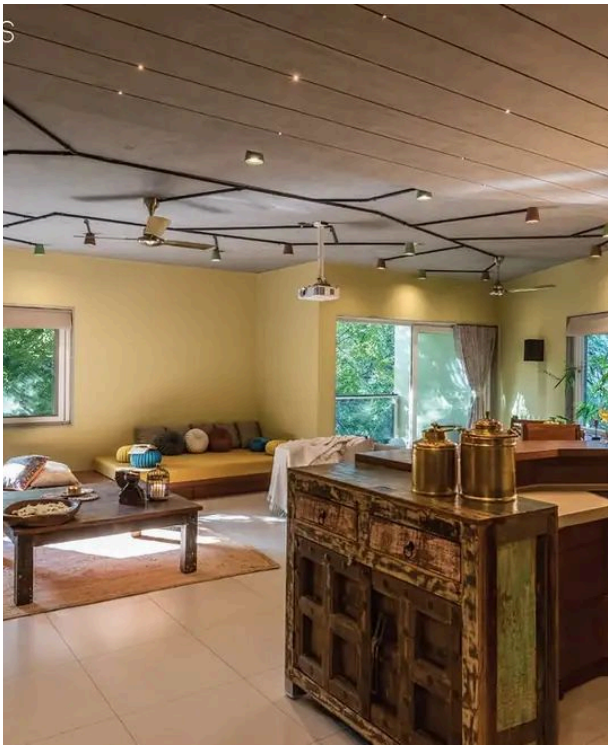
3

Materials you can almost touch

Print is a slow, close medium. Readers linger on a page in a way they never linger on a phone. That is where materials win.

Show the stone, the grain of the wood, the weave of the fabric, the way light falls on a lime-plaster wall. Then tell the editor where each one came from and why you chose it.

Two or three materials, explained well, will do more for your feature than a long list of brands.



A home by KDA, from its Sylph cover story.

4

The people behind the work

Readers remember people more than logos. An editor wants to know who you are, how your practice started and what you believe about design.

Have a good portrait ready: you, or your team, in one of your own spaces. Natural, not stiff.



Isha Arora of Isha Arora Designs on the cover of Sylph, at home with her dog. People connect with people.

FROM THE PAGES

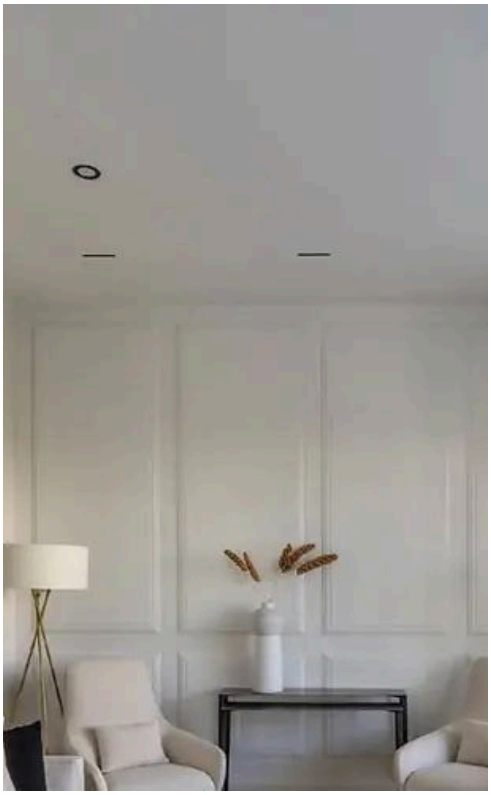
Design Net's feature told the story of two generations: a practice founded in 1988 by Ar. Abhay Srivastava, now led by Ar. Shruti S. Gulati and Ar. Chiranjeev Gulati.

5

Photographs an editor can actually use

You do not need hundreds of photographs. You need the right 15 to 25. Brief your photographer with this list.

The hero	One photograph that tells the whole story in a single frame. This often decides the opening page.
The wide views	Four to six photographs of the main spaces, shot straight and level, with the lights on.
The details	Four to six close-ups: joinery, stone, hardware, textiles, a light fitting you designed.
The materials	Two or three tight shots where the reader can almost feel the surface.
The outside	The facade or the view, at the best hour of the day. Early morning or dusk, usually.
The life	One or two quiet human moments: a table set, a book left open. With the owner's permission.
The portrait	You or your team, in the space. Relaxed and well lit.



A living room by Magic Houz, from its Sylph feature.

BEFORE YOU SEND

- ✓ Send the original files from your photographer. Images forwarded on WhatsApp lose detail and do not print well.
- ✓ Shoot key rooms both upright and sideways. Pages are upright. Spreads are wide.
- ✓ Keep vertical lines straight and colours true. No heavy filters.

6

A finished, lived-in space

Editors feature homes, not sites. Wait until the last curtain is up, the art is hung and the furniture has arrived.

Then style it, lightly. Fresh flowers, a few books, cushions plumped. It should look like someone lives there, not like a showroom.

A smaller project that is finished and well shot beats a grand one that is still under scaffolding.



A living room by Yellow Arch Studio, from its Sylph feature.

7

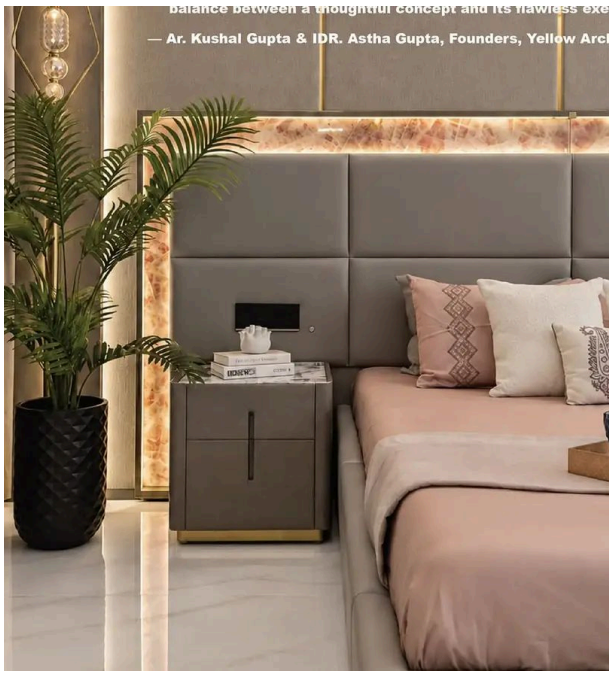
The right moment

Print works on a calendar. Sylph publishes four editions a month, and booked places run first come, first served, in the order material arrives.

So send early. Shoot as soon as the project is finished. Material in by the middle of a month usually runs the month after.

If you have a launch, an award entry or a big pitch coming up, tell the editor early. Timing can often be matched to it.

> "Good design does not always have to be loud to make an impact."
>
> AR. KUSHAL GUPTA AND IDR ASTHA GUPTA, YELLOW ARCH STUDIO, IN SYLPH



PART TWO

5 mistakes that keep good projects out

None of these are about talent. All of them are easy to fix once you know.

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1 Sending everything

Eighty photographs and no story. The editor has to do your work for you, and usually will not. Send your best 15 to 25, in an order that walks the reader through the home, from the entrance to the most private room.

2 Renders where photographs are needed

For a home or an interior, editors want the real, finished space. Save renders for projects that are not built yet, and say clearly that they are renders.

3 Forgetting the homeowner

Your clients value their privacy. Get their written consent before photographs go anywhere, and agree on what stays out: family photographs, house numbers, art that identifies them.

4 Paying an agent for a page

Many magazine pages are sold through agents. A page that costs ₹3 lakh can be sold to you for ₹4.5 lakh, with ₹1.5 lakh kept as the agent's cut. Ask the magazine directly for its fixed price.

5 Waiting for the perfect project

The perfect project rarely arrives. A finished, well-shot project you are proud of today is worth more than a dream project that is two years away.

PART THREE

3 things few designers are told

NOTE 1

Your first three photographs do most of the work

Editors see a lot of work. Assume yours is judged on the opening images. Put your hero shot first, then your two strongest rooms. Save the details for later.

NOTE 2

A feature keeps working long after the edition

Once your work is in print, use it. Show the pages to new clients, add them to your website and proposals, and keep a copy in your studio.

NOTE 3

The right readers matter more than the most readers

A feature is only as useful as the people who read it. Sylph is hand-delivered to UHNI and HNI homes from its own list, so your work is seen by the families who commission homes like yours.



Sylph in hard copy. Four editions a month, 400 pages each.

> "Having our work published with an editor's voice gave our firm the exact third-person authority we needed to close our largest UHNI project to date."
>
> A SYLPH CLIENT

USE THIS BEFORE YOU SEND ANYTHING

The Press-Worthy checklist

Tick every line, and you are ready for an editor. Miss a few, and you know exactly what to fix.

- [ ] I can say what this project is about in one sentence
- [ ] There is one clear idea that runs through every room
- [ ] I know the two or three materials I want to talk about, and where they came from
- [ ] The project is finished, styled and ready to be photographed
- [ ] I have 15 to 25 professional photographs, in a sensible order
- [ ] My hero shot is first, and it tells the whole story
- [ ] Key rooms are shot both upright and sideways
- [ ] I have the original, full-size files, not WhatsApp copies
- [ ] I have a good portrait of me or my team, in one of our spaces
- [ ] The homeowner has agreed, in writing, to the photographs being published
- [ ] I have written the 150-word story on the next page
- [ ] I know which edition I am aiming for, and its closing date

WORKSHEET

Your project in 150 words

Editors write the story, but they need the facts from you. Fill this in and you have everything they need, in one place.

The client, without names (A family of five who wanted…)

The brief, in one line

The big idea

The hardest constraint, and how you solved it

Three materials, and where they came from

The room you are proudest of, and why

Who did what (Studio, team, collaborators, photographer)

MAKE IT COUNT

After it is published

A feature is not a one-day event. Here is how studios make one feature work for the whole year.

Put it in every proposal

A page from Sylph says more about your work than a list of past clients.

Add it to your website

Show the pages themselves under "As featured in", not just a logo.

Keep copies in your studio

A client waiting for a meeting will pick it up. Some studios frame their cover.

Send it to the homeowner

They will show it to the people they know. Many of them build homes too.

Share it online

On Instagram and LinkedIn, crediting Sylph, your team and your photographer.

Plan the next one

A second feature a year later shows a practice that keeps producing work worth reading about.



Sylph in hard copy, on a side table.



A dining room by Design Net, from its Sylph feature.

FROM RECENT EDITIONS

What a Sylph feature looks like



The cover: KDA's Deepali and Kunal Meni.



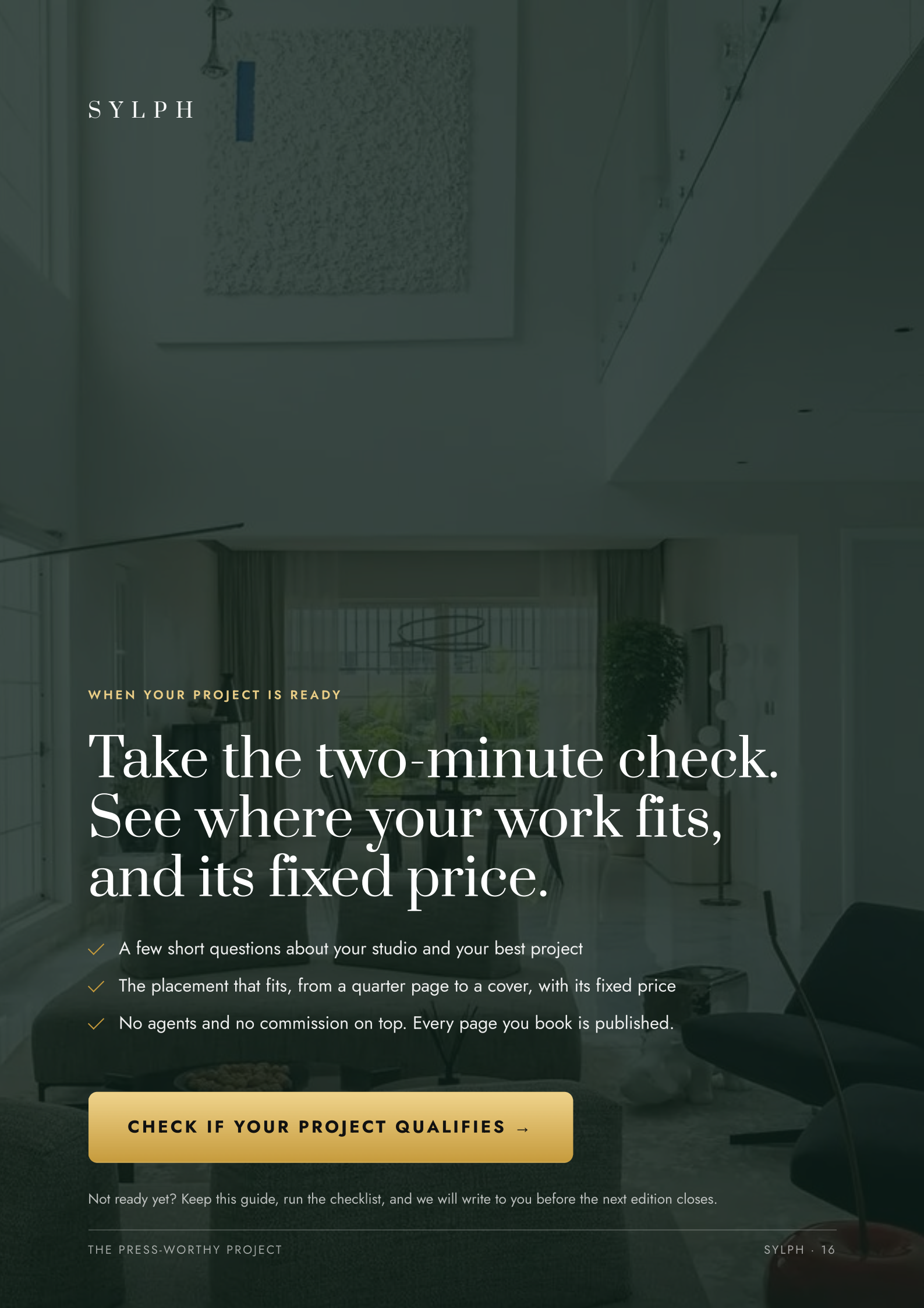
The founders: The Design Unit's profile.



The project: MuseLAB's Gingham Dreams.



The book: Essentia's own Legacy Book™.



WHEN YOUR PROJECT IS READY

Take the two-minute check. See where your work fits, and its fixed price.

- A few short questions about your studio and your best project
- The placement that fits, from a quarter page to a cover, with its fixed price
- No agents and no commission on top. Every page you book is published.

CHECK IF YOUR PROJECT QUALIFIES →

Not ready yet? Keep this guide, run the checklist, and we will write to you before the next edition closes.